

QUALITY OF SLEEP | EXERCISE 2

Record Your Quality of Sleep

In Exercise 1 you assessed your sleep quality and made changes to incorporate some Best Practice principles. As an alternative approach, Exercise 2 combines journalling with recording and reviewing your daily sleep pattern.



Journalling about daily experiences helps us process these events, which frees up our brains and leads to better sleep, improved working memory, reduced stress and anxiety, improved self-awareness, self-confidence and overall well-being.

1

In the evening, write about the key events of your day using the table on the next page. Record how long you slept for and rate the quality of that sleep. Reflect on what may have impacted your sleep quality, both negatively and positively.

2

Complete this for 7 days to see if there are any areas you could work on to improve your quality of sleep, and to see what works for you.

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Date	Key events of the day	Hours of sleep	Quality of sleep on a scale of 1-10 1 = very bad 10 = excellent	In the morning-possible reason for sleep quality

Remember to incorporate these key components:

- Maintain a regular sleep schedule of 7-9 hrs to reinforce your circadian rhythm.
- Work with your Chronotype not against.
- Eliminate or limit daytime naps.
- Environment: Create a comfortable sleep environment.
- Reduce exposure to: TV, phones and electronic devices 30-60 mins before bed.
- Don't do vigorous exercise < 60 mins before bed, do relaxing exercise.
- Food intake: Don't eat too late and avoid caffeine.
- Relaxation Techniques: Breathing exercises, a warm bath.
- Physical Activity: Regular exercise can improve sleep quality.

Detailed explanations can be found on the next page.

QUALITY OF SLEEP | BEST PRACTICE

Improving Sleep Quality - Best Practice

Enhance your resilience by incorporating these sleep hygiene habits:

1. Reinforce your circadian rhythm with a regular sleep pattern of 7-9 hours.
2. Early bird, or night owl? Understand and adapt to your chronotype - do focus work when most alert / go to bed when tired, to improve sleep quality, energy, mood, performance.
3. Night owls may have trouble sleeping, so try shifting your circadian rhythm earlier. Consistently exercising at 7am and good sleep hygiene has been shown to shift circadian rhythm.
4. Walk outside within an hour of waking, daylight synchronises your circadian rhythm.
5. Deep Sleep and REM are improved by daily fresh air and exercise. They are critical to creativity, memory, learning, insightful thinking, and protection against dementia.
6. Incorporate daily physical activity to improve sleep quality including 7,000 steps/day preferably outside, evening relaxing exercise e.g. yoga, to increase REM, Deep Sleep, and melatonin (primary sleep hormone).
7. Limit naps to 20 minutes and eat protein at lunchtime to avoid an energy slump.
8. Create a bedtime routine to relax your mind and body, such as journalling, meditation, reading, breathing exercises or a warm bath.
9. Good Nutrition helps quality sleep:-
 - have your last meal at least 3 hours before going to bed to allow your body time to process it.
 - avoid alcohol and caffeine sources such as chocolate, tea, coffee, and soda from 5pm or earlier. These can cause interrupted sleep and reduce deep sleep.
 - Increase melatonin production with probiotics such as kefir, eat tryptophan-rich foods (turkey, nuts, seeds).
 - Choose relaxing exercise not vigorous exercise <60 mins before bed.
10. Make your bedroom as comfortable as possible, at the right temperature (c. 65F/18C). Reduce light and sound using black-out curtains, eye mask, ear plugs, or white-noise devices.
11. Switch off electronic devices 30-60 mins before bed, they emit blue light which inhibits the production of melatonin.
12. If you can't fall asleep within 30 minutes, get up and leave the bedroom. Read or do another quiet activity for 15 to 20 minutes until you get sleepy.